things they don't deserve to be involved in. Sometimes that might just be something spiteful in a newspaper column. I can deal with that myself: phone the bloke up and tell him he's out of order. That's what I've done in the past. But a threat to my boys' safety? Their lives, even? How am I supposed to know what to do about that? It's only when those things happen that you realize you have to do something, have to talk to people who think about the unthinkable for a living. You never know what may happen: when the case against last year's alleged kidnappers got thrown out of court after all the publicity in the *News of the World*, it left us not knowing where we stood. All I can tell you is those threats felt very real—and very frightening—at the time. And if Victoria and the boys are the potential targets, I can't take any risks about how serious or not the threats might be.

If it's your family's safety you want to protect, it's very hard to judge who the right person, or people, might be to turn to for advice. Like with everything else in your life, you start with those closest to you. I'm lucky that my father-in-law actually knows a bit about the hardware and technology side of it all: it's in his line of work. The police have always tried to do right by us and we've always tried to check staff out as carefully as we could. But who hasn't misjudged a person at some time in his life? Of course, we've made our mistakes.

It's not a subject where you can ever say: this is solved. I can't even say I'm sure I'd know what 'solved' might be: there's not a 'How To' book you can check to make sure you're doing the right things. It's about balancing the need for a normal life with taking what precautions you can. You can't live every day making sure the world can't get near you. But you shouldn't have to live with fear either, on edge all the time, imagining that something bad could be about to happen. Right now, I feel pretty comfortable with the people we have looking after us. I trust them enough for us not to be spending all our time watching our backs.

The time after France 98 was pretty uncomfortable, to say the least. But before then, and since, it's not as if I've felt under any kind of constant threat: you're guarding against the hundred-to-one chance. But feeling secure leaves us freer to get on with doing what we do, publicly and privately. We like to take Brooklyn and Romeo out to dinner sometimes. We want to stop off to stock up on snacks. We want to go shopping at the local supermarket, shlepping up and down the aisles and choosing what we fancy, instead of going on the internet or ordering by phone. I still feel, deep down, like the person I've always been. If I want it to stay that way, I've got to make sure I can still do the things I've always done. I've never had a problem with people